

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

GENDER

Kuch Toh Log

A day after Vinesh Phogat's stunning Olympic disqualification, an analysis of the media and political machinery that shaped public perception of the wrestler — tracing the arc from the 2023 Wrestlers' Protest against BJP MP Brij Bhushan to the disinformation campaigns that followed her to Paris.

BY MOULI SHARMA

Alag Aurat, Wah! Gaaliyan



Design by Shruti Patel

8th August 2024: A day after 3-time Commonwealth Champion Vinesh Phogat's disqualification from the Olympic games post a sensational & unprecedented run to the event finale in Paris, much has happened. Developments in the Olympian's case - one already clouded by a complicated & tragic political history - have been unrelenting & unpredictable.

The 2023 Wrestlers Protest, which took place in Delhi as an outcry against the sexual abuse of female wrestlers in the WFI under the chairmanship of & by then Bharatiya Janata Party MP Brij Bhushan, & included sportspeople of international acclaim & prestige like Sakshi Malik, Bajrang Punia, & of course the titular Phogat herself - were largely ignored by the mainstream media in favour of less polarising issues. What minimal coverage it received in the digital & independent media sphere, then, was overshadowed & competing with other humanitarian crises such as the 2024 Farmer's Protests , Manipur violence , Gazan Genocide - the list goes on.



It seems now, though, as if these protests, of which Vinesh was a pivotal part & had to suffer the consequences of in career as well as in body (the wrestlers were subjected to horrific police brutality see: Wrestlers Detained Trying To March To New Parliament, Protest Site Cleared) alongside her compatriots in the cause, are finally getting the attention they deserved.

Vinesh's disqualification has led to something of a 'Streisand Effect' within the world of Indian Wrestling, an act of suspicious & arbitrary cruelty that has ignited national & media interest in the very abuse & corruption of the WFI that the wrestler was on the streets of Delhi fighting less than a year ago. Her breathtaking performance in Paris has guaranteed that neither the Olympic Association's blatant endangerment of female athletes nor getting dragged through the asphalt in 2023 has been for naught. And it is this, not any nationalist platitude or pitiful consolation or meaningless expression of secondhand pride, that makes her a victor.

In spite of the humiliation & the relentless efforts to deny her dues, in spite of the violence & the abuse & the pungent stink of political foul play , in spite of the simple human heartbreak of being beaten down by your own country, sport & people, Vinesh Phogat has not lost . In a much larger sense than the 'you're still a winner in our books!' & the 'you lost the medal but won our hearts' articles & social media posts circling the internet will reveal, Vinesh Phogat achieved something on the mat at Paris that few athletes in their lifetimes ever even dream of trying for. She fought back her dignity.

But in such circumstances - where media organizations have been eager & quick to cash in on the intense but always brief public interest by pumping out 100-word 'articles' by the dozen in fear of explaining away anything too well lest the reader remain no longer desperate for more, thereby manufacturing new utility for explainer articles to resolve the confusion they helped create - it is easy to get buried under the rubble of journalistic noise; overinformation, virality, fake news; the likes.

Tale of Two Medals

Late captain Anshuman Singh was a medical officer who lost his life trying to save others in a fire accident where he was posted at the Siachen Glacier. He was a brave man who didn't want to die an ordinary death , & his posthumous reception of the Kirti Chakra - India's second highest peacetime gallantry honour after the Ashok - stands proof that he didn't. His story is one of insurmountable courage, of selflessness in the face of death, & it deserves to be remembered as such, especially in a country that much sooner wants to honour, remember & defend its soldiers once they're dead than when they live.

1. Pretty Privilege

Captain Anshuman's passing first received mention in the news thirteen months ago , briefly & unsubstantially, when reports of the fire accident in which he lost his life first broke into the media, the same day his partner of over 8 years received a call that told her her husband was no more. The story was undetailed & nominal, & was mostly relegated to the digital sections of mainstream newspapers, & received no follow-ups.

Contrary to what the recent controversy involving his will & death will imply, Anshuman Singh has not been a household name to Indians either before or after his sacrifice, even within defence news circles. In fact, even after the announcement and awarding of his Kirti Chakra in the Defence Investiture Ceremony of 2023, his name was not known or publicised. The DIC itself, is not a widely reported event any year. Because as much as the news articles later exaggerating the details & value of the Kirti Chakra would hate to admit it, Gallantry awards aren't interesting. Not when there are 36 of them being handed out together.

It was routine. So what changed?

A day after the conduct of the DIC, a video tweet of Smriti shared by the Ministry of Defence Spokesperson filmed after the completion of Singh's posthumous medal ceremony was posted on X. The account, run under the username A. Bharat Bhushan Babu , typically posted anywhere between 5-10 tweets daily at the time, which garnered negligible views & shares despite the account having over 4L followers at time of writing & an X verification. The post featuring Smriti was one of many, many tweets made about DIC awardees - 7 of whom had in fact received the Kirti Chakra posthumously - & was likely to get buried under the countless tweets of its kind that were to come. 'Phase I' of interviews of widows, mothers, & grieving children in black & white filters, blood repayed with VIP handshakes & bouquets - Smriti's story was as tragic as it was ordinary.

But it didn't. The tweet went viral. With nearly 8L views & over 12,000 likes, it is one of the most successful tweets of the account's entire timeline. Soon, an awardee that was merely one of 36 gallantry medallists - none worth the time & effort of individual reportage - that even the official X handle of the Defence Ministry Spokesperson couldn't be bothered to post about the same day, became newsworthy .

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<https://twitter.com/SpokespersonMoD/status/1804690004999378>

The headlines on the 6th of July across media houses read some variant of quotes from the viral video itself, from ‘Won’t die an ordinary death’ to ‘It was love at first sight.’ By the 7th of July, Smriti had become the face of military sacrifice & honour to social media warriors & chronic X news-watchers, posting & reposting photographs of her weeping face on their personal & corporate accounts with heartfelt captions, public performances of grief & sympathy. And when it was discovered that according to certain people, it was a very nice face indeed, the keyboards started to burn.

2. R*ndi

As per widespread reports - largely written by uncredited authors & journalists - a now-deleted lewd comment made on a photograph of Smriti posted by Facebook user Arjun Singh Head from a profile named Ahmad K. led to the National Commission of Women taking Suo Motu action, but none of these reports cites or links the Facebook post in question (remember this for later), whether as a link if it was still up or through archives if it had already been taken down. X user @KumaarSaagar tweeted a screenshot of what was assumed to be the original post with the caption, “Shameful. What else can you expect from that Ahmad who looks at his own sister this way?” on the 8th of July, 2024 at 12:24 PM, which is what the NCW finally came across & referred in her official complaint. The tweet now has 858k views, more than Smriti’s original interview to date.

<https://twitter.com/SpokespersonMoD/status/1804690004999378>

tweet that led to the National Commission for Women taking notice & eventual legal action.

The (former) National Commission of India chairwoman Rekha Sharma happened upon the tweet sometime before 4PM the same day, & decided to take Suo Motu action. Within 4 hours, not only was an official letter written to the Commissioner of Police by the NCW for the immediate arrest of ‘Ahmad K.’ but the same was also scanned & tweeted (see below) on NCW’s official X handle.

All of this for a tweet that was a screenshot of a Facebook post of a screenshot of a Facebook comment on the X account of a self-proclaimed ‘news company’, one that has a reputation for posting videos & images that are criminal, doctored, falsely captioned, unsourced & designed to manufacture communal unrest.

Continuing the unprecedented pattern of swift & shocking action in a case of digital trolling, an FIR was in fact claimed to be filed against an ‘Ahmad K.’ by the Delhi Police immediately, & in resulting interviews with ANI, NCW Chairwoman Rekha Sharma went as far as to say that an FIR would be filed for every lewd comment made about Smriti, under violation of Section 79 of the Bharat Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 & Section 67 of the IT Act, 2000. But as was already made obvious by the dozens of tweets replying to the NCW that pointed out similar comments made by users who weren’t named Ahmad or Mohammad, no such action took place, or it appears was ever intended to.

<https://twitter.com/durgapaln/status/1804705862418240>

Just like that, by the 9th of July, a new series of headlines had avalanched over Anshuman Singh’s name, whose subject was Smriti & Smriti alone (Moneycontrol , Firstpost & Jagran even went as far as to have the exact same headline: ‘Who is Smriti Singh, widow of Army Captain Anshuman Singh who died in Siachen’). Funnily enough, Smriti herself was never even involved; her consent, her wishes, or her opinion - none was deemed much too important in the discourse around her dignity. Not by the NCW & not by the Delhi Police, institutions claiming to act in defence of her honour. As quick as it formed, the agenda had mutated; the tragedy of Anshuman’s death having been overrun by a newer, more made-up tragedy: the targeting of his wife by lewd trolls, specifically, trolls with Muslim names.

The Hindu Alt Right’s bid succeeded, & mainstream media picked up the sensationalist matter gleefully. For the convenience of headlines, Anshuman went from a medical officer to an ‘Indian Army Soldier’ of unspecified designation, some even going as far as to refer to him as a martyr, or implying he was killed in action. After all, the title ‘army medic dies saving three in completely avoidable fire incident’ raises questions, not patriotism.

On the 8th of July, it began to morph & bend at political & communal angles as its natural progression. Compilations of lewd comments made by ‘Muslim’ usernames began cropping all over the Indian Memesphere (at time of writing, no other lewd remarks from Muslim users can be found in the original comment sections, though they could’ve just as well been deleted or drowned out) - comments not much unlike those that are now being made by the decidedly Hindu supporters of Brij Bhushan celebrating & mocking Vinesh’s disqualification all over Social media right now. The difference is that this time, the National Commission for Women doesn’t seem to care.

https://twitter.com/citizen_idiot/status/1804705862418240

tweet by TVE Editor mouli Sharma has fewer than 100 views, & is the most recent reply in the thread (at time of writing).

Then again, one can always argue, correctly, that it never really did.

NCW’s tweet of their demand for Ahmad K’s arrest acted as fuel for hate speech & Islamophobia , an opportunity that was gobbled up by the Hindu Alt-Right, peddling a narrative that vilified Muslims & exploited the convenience of rearing sentiments when it came to disrespecting not just a woman, not just the wife of a soldier, but the grieving, helpless wife a dead Indian soldier; a Hindu man’s Hindu woman. It was a storm no one would’ve anticipated a single Facebook comment about fuckable women in the Indian digital sphere could ever snowball into. But it did.

Right?

3. Biwi Kaun Lega

Remember in the previous section where it states that mainstream reports omitted citations or attributions of the original Facebook comment made by the supposed profile of ‘Ahmad K’? Well this slight journalistic compromise reveals something far more sinister about the way Indian news takes shape & form than it appears to, & the explanation lies in a very simple fact that if you’re very clever, will tell you everything there is to know: NCW did not tweet about the ‘lewd comment’ after the controversy broke, but before.

There’s a mass media phenomenon called ‘agenda setting theory’ which was a term first coined by Maxwell McCombs & Donald Shaw, & is now a well-established schism of modern news & media systems. The way it works is this: if a media house talks about one thing once, it may fade away from the public consciousness if it isn’t worth remembering, depending on what the public consciousness decides. If a media house talks about that same thing all the time, it will be remembered, & the public will have that decision taken from them without them even realising it. Its implications for the way we look at news, mass media & our sense of agency in a modern democracy are humbling & huge. You do not decide what is important to you; the news oligarchy does.

<https://www.researchgate.net/publication/322602862/figure/fig/1/figure-fig1/1517222222222/Traditional-Agenda-Setting-Models-L-Guo-The-application-of-social-network-analysis-in-agenda-setting-research-A-methodological-exploration-Journal-of-Broadcasting-&Electronic-Media-Vol-56-2012-no-4-p-619.png>

When NCW’s official X handle tweeted about having ‘identified’ a lewd comment from ‘Ahmad K.’ & announced their formal communication with the Delhi Police take action via @mention, it was up to Times of India, India Today, NDTV, Firstpost, Times Now & their countless subsidiaries to decide what, if anything, was newsworthy about the tweet. NCW’s new & revolutionary power of high-speed unprompted FIR, the countless users in the replies clarifying over & over that Ahmad K. was not the sole perpetrator of his chosen crime, the question of what a precedent of a man going to jail for calling a woman a whore on the internet would mean for society at large & all others were rejected in favour of a more traditionalist angle: paraphrasing the tweet itself into news.

If any of them had bothered to look into it - the Delhi Police, the NCW, the News, it really doesn’t matter who; there was plety of opportunity every step of the way - they would have found that Ahmad K’s comment was not a coincidence turned into communal agenda, but a communal agenda from the very beginning. Retracing the path of how the NCW happened upon Ahmad’s Facebook comment, TVE discovered that the lone screenshot had gone through not one or two but three profiles of anti-muslim hate speech accounts, starting out from one that perhaps wasn’t too convenient to cite: that of a self-proclaimed ‘ex-Muslim Atheist’ named Jafar Ahmed himself.

https://www.facebook.com/permalink.php?story_fbid=pfbid02cYxv5M9FSX4r8sGjZ8jdlWtSaaghpz28Eva6RcBtI

All of old Indian media collectively decided about 5 years ago (ballpark figure) to say ‘fuck it’ instead of doing the bare minimum of their jobs & verifying anything at all, & it matters because it allows for cartoonish situations like this: Pak twist in row over obscene comment on Captain Anshuman Singh’s widow , to happen.

Now, beyond comedy, there are a few serious questions that arise when one realises that we as a nation have got to a point where a written document was typed, printed, submitted to the police by a national organisation, self-publicised via an internet microblog, had a resulting FIR supposedly filed & an arrest process begun - & at no point during the course of this expedited legal & bureaucratic process was the question asked: just who is the person we are trying to put in jail?

The implications of Ahmad K’s country of origin coming as a shock to the police & NCW are worrying & absurd, not least because this entire debacle took place under Suo Motu jurisdiction. For those still wondering, this would mean that the NCW chairwoman began legal proceedings based on an untested screenshot that she selected from an already biased source, without even having the comment or user profile verified first. Conflicts of interest arise here not once or twice but repeatedly, muddying every step of the investigative with maplpractice & neglect.

The casual nature with which the dialogue & reporting of this supposedly ‘serious matter’ took place poses doubt as to whether the NCW chairwoman or the Jafar Ahmed himself, the user who had even bothered to check if a Facebook profile & comment by Ahmad K. had ever existed at all. The real identity behind ‘Ahmad K.’s profile is still unknown, meaning there could be anyone behind the username - a woman, a child; a Hindu. Communal tension overblowing in the national capital is no lighthearted matter, & had it gone out of twitter & into streets only to later surface as having originated from a disingenuous account, all of it would’ve been for nothing.

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There are far too many ways in which an unvetted digital image having been used as legal evidence against an unverified social media account could have gone very, very wrong, especially in a matter of communal sensitivity, & it's through the grace of luck, not caution that it didn't. Rekha Sharma's actions as NCW chairperson were willfully neglectful, discriminatory, & very likely an intentional attempt at exasperating communal contempt. Her consequent indifference to the online abuse of women, including Smriti herself (see next section) further exemplifies her actions as nothing but a blatant abuse of authority, & she alongside the Delhi Police in complicity requires immediate investigation. Making a national controversy out of a facebook comment is nothing short of a mockery of the rule of law. It is worth mentioning that even the cartoonish end-stage headlines where Pakistan itself was brought into the mix, were about yet another tweet. It took AltNews co-founder Mohommed Zubair less than four hours to track down the original post, & in a reply to NCW's thread, he even warned them that the user had changed his location from Karachi, Pakistan to Delhi, India. A day later, in an interview with ANI, Rekha Sharma told reporters that the user was 'probably Pakistani, anyway', with no mention of how she recieved the intel, making the omission noteworthy considering the Government's dislike of Zubair & AltNews as one of many fact-		Again, instead of questions being raised over how such crucial & obvious information could've been overlooked before reaching out to the Commissioner of Police, or whether the whole thing was just a publicity stunt, the countless big-name media houses that had thoughtlessly amplified the situation without prior investigation or verification jumped into a new & embarrassingly foolish angle - of Pakistani conspiracy. The incident casts the trustworthiness & journalistic credibility of all participating media houses in serious doubt. If nothing else, this report should serve as an annexure of all the news sites that published unverified & inaccurate articles in the second week of July - Times of India even goes as far as to get basic details like Anshuman's age & years of marriage wrong, attention-seeking & sensationalist in the most disrespectful of ways. And of course, of course - They didn't stop there. 4. Cheater Cheater Chor Chor Not unlike Vinesh, for all the concern that the right-wing digital diaspora had for Smriti from the 6th to the 9th of July, they turned on her quick. https://www.instagram.com/p/C-X3oHzvUpt/?img_index=3Award winning journalist Tanushree Pandey compiles hateful reporting from mainstream news channels & social media users.		It is worth noting that through the first half of what was supposed to be a week of vindication & honour for the surviving widow - which later turned into a hellish nightmare as her life and character were made the home of public discourse, opinion & speculation - she wasn't present in the news. To date, the only public address that Smriti Singh has made has been the short clip she most likely didn't volunteer to record, trying to commemorate her late husband at the behest of the government for whom he gave his life. 1. The DJB was visited for the article, meaning a great deal of effort was put into the research for it, making it more trustworthy. 2. Officials of the DJB engaged with the journalists, & if people in places of higher authority find this journalist & media house worth engaging with, then they must have a respectable identity, & I can safely take them seriously. Now, if it were to be revealed that the DJB had held a press conference, meaning journalists from every media house around the city would have gotten the quote, it would have made it a bit less exclusive & therefore less impressive, but the effort & officiality of it would remain. If it were revealed that there wasn't a press conference or a physical visit at all, but rather an email communication, more novelty would be lost, but the effort would still count. If it were revealed that the quote in fact comes from a tweet, or the about section of an official government website, all credibility would be lost at once. But by omitting just that tiny bit of information, the very same article would glide by with the benefit of both assumptions, with the effort & credibility needed for neither, which is why it matters when news pretends it took place off of Twitter when it happened deep within. From the 6th till the 10th of July, there wasn't a Smriti Singh behind the words being quoted, requoted, defended, protected, debated, etc. in the articles that were written under her name. A video made to a microphone & camera, & photographs posted by strangers. Smriti Singh was never even reached out to for another quote, not even when an FIR was being filed on her behalf. Perhaps she didn't want to be. Or perhaps she wasn't worth the effort. Not when the mirage of her video worked so well & better. Her parents-in-law, on the other hand, were happy to talk to the media. And the media was just as happy to talk to them. They were constantly in touch with central news agencies, from which individual channels solicit interviews & field reports. All of TOI & HT & FP & their infinite horizontal & vertical counterparts, writing about Smriti's parents-in-law & the justice they felt she deserved from vicious internet trolls... except they didn't feel any such thing. The only thing they ever wanted to talk about was how she'd left them & her home of marriage, along with her husband's Kirti Chakra & possessions.		https://twitter.com/StruggleLo57650/status/1576508142950884819 & posts targeting Reshma also distinguishes the 'gold digger' controversy from the 'lewd comments' controversy in another crucial sense, beyond statistical legitimacy: intent. It's very important to note that all of the 'lewd comments' doing the rounds on the internet, whether paid heed to by the NCW ('Badi cute hai yaar mai toh chomdu ga isy') or not (all the rest), is that every single one of them was made under posts made by people other than Smriti herself, presumably without her knowledge or consent. It's clear the comments weren't made with the intention of finding Smriti; certainly, it's possible that they were made with the intention of not finding her. But Reshma's case proves that the same can hardly be said about those who set out to burn her at the stake for daring to return to her maiden home with her husbands clothes, books, medal, & woman. Dogli Duniya Vinesh's Olympic journey only visibly became a point of contention to Brij Bhushan's supporters once she was out of the race. For the most part through her ascent to the Olympic finals, it was a different crowd making noise. The people who couldn't take their eyes off of Vinesh as she shattered Indian expectations on the mat game after game were the same ones, who less than a year ago, couldn't help but look the other way.		Now that she is being silenced & disgraced in the cruelest manner possible for an international athlete, it is our duty as women, countrymen, sportspeople, journalists, citizens - whoever & whatever we may be - to not fail her again. It is our duty to grab institutes like the National Commission for Women & the International Olympic Committee by the neck & turn them her way. 'Look', we must tell them. 'Look', we must tell ourselves. We owe it to her to keep our eyes open as she breaks. We owe it to her to bear witness. This is where it becomes crucial to analyse the chronologies of the news & digital evolutions of the two controversies in tandem with each other, because by intervening in an incident of digital trolling as commonplace as a lone sexually colored Facebook remark, the NCW established not only cultural but legal precedent. Everyone knows what section 67 of the IT Act, 2000 says, they have for a quarter of a century. But citizens - victims - attempting to file an FIR against one crude social media comment will not only be laughed out of police stations but also be crucified in the court of public opinion, often reasonably. The NCW on the other hand, seems to have the privilege to decide otherwise, a privilege it displayed on July 8th, by its self-proclaimed 'Suo Motu action' taken & papered voluntarily in a matter of hours, announced in the form of a literal tweet. Because it seems, that when the usernames are Muslim, investigative & bureaucratic procedures become optional.		Who decides who she is worth protecting from? Two Women, Same Hell https://twitter.com/alliseeisgold/Burroughs tweet now has over 8M views. Neither Smriti nor Vinesh would have had the slightest inkling of the other's existence little over a year ago. Unbeknownst to each other, they lived out the worst months of their life, survived, & just when they thought it was over, just when they thought it was finally going to get better, they had to go through it all again. Vinesh was called a liar when she raised her voice against Brij Bhushan's tyranny of abuse. She was dragged through the mud in body for breaking her silence last year & on Twitter for losing at the Olympics. She was called a traitor then, for not meeting their expectations, 7 she's being called a cheater now, for shattering them. And we know perfectly well who they are. It comes as no surprise that it is the right-wing BJP supporting fascist Hindu diaspora on both sides of our story, that is celebrating the pain & humiliation of Vinesh, a survivor, & that very same diaspora who called Smriti 'evil' & a thief when there were no more Muslims left to defend her from. Remember Facebook user 'Arjun Singh Head', whose sans-consent post of Smriti's picture on his personal account was what started it all just a month before now? 3 days ago, an account by the same name shared a poster of Vinesh & Sarah Hilderbrandt's final, with a caption saying that he hoped 'the one in blue' would win. That he hoped Vinesh would lose.	

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https://www.facebook.com/permalink.php?story_fbid=pfbido2LRub4sTnuKfHd3xzvVlt3ytn4BVhGtGboysdGZME9qJ

As of 11th August 2024, the post is no longer visible.

That's them.

They called the games rigged when she won, & they called it karma when she was made to lose. They called her a warrior when she wore white & cried, & they called her a thief when she decided to move on. They blamed her for losing the medal & they blamed her for taking it home. They fought a battle she didn't ask them to fight & they turned the other ear when she screamed at them to join in hers. They cried she was a cheater for being too good to be true, & they knew she was a gold-digger when she wasn't good enough. They called her a liar without letting her speak, & they called her a whore because she tried to speak out.

Without either of them knowing - someone, somewhere, somehow tied the strings of Smriti & Vinesh's fates together. Intertwined like it's destiny, or like it'll make good fucking drama on fucking Twitter nay X. They don't know it, but they went through hell together. They don't know it, but they survived.

People will always have something to say.

See Also

- <https://www.news18.com/video/4BVhGtGboysdGZME9qJ>

is a smriti influencer- mistaken-for-captain-anshuman-singhs-wife-hits-back-at-trolls-8968381.html

2. Sodhi, August 10th 2024, Five highlights from Rekha Sharma's misogynist tenure as National Women's Commission chief , The News Minute

3. <https://www.timesnownews.com/sports/india/given-death-threats-labelled-traitor-after-olympics-says-vinesh-phogat-as-wrestlers-stage-protest-against-wfi-article-97090197>

4. <https://www.indiatoday.in/india/story/is-harish-salve-vinesh-phogat-paris-olympics-disqualification-case-2579676-2024-08-09>

5. <https://theprint.in/opinion/singh-is-no-gold-digger-her-greatest-transgression-is-her-refusal-to-be-buried-alive/2187278/>

6. <https://www.espn.in/olympic/story/vinesh-phogat-world-lucky-part-paris-olympics-2024>



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